THE NINE-TIME CM

Nitish has been an indispensable part of the Bihar government for the past two decades

1. Mar. 3-Mar. 10, 2000
Alliance with BJP: Nitish quit in seven days as he couldn't make the numbers, but it raised hopes that a Lalu-less regime was possible

2. Nov. 24, 2005-Nov. 25, 2010
Alliance with BJP: Nitish and BJP stormed to power after 2005's second assembly election (first one was dissolved)



3. Nov. 26, 2010-May 19, 2014
Alliance with BJP/ RJD-Cong.: Huge victory turns bitter by 2013 as Nitish leaves NDA over Modi's rise in BJP. Quits CM post after LS poll debacle

4. Feb. 22-Nov. 19, 2015
Alliance with RJD-Cong.: Eight months before assembly polls, Nitish returns as CM, ejecting Jitan Ram Manjhi whom he had installed in 2014

5. Nov. 20, 2015-Jul. 26, 2017
Alliance with RJD-Cong.: Another big assembly poll win but leaves alliance in 2017 over CBI raid on Lalu, corruption taint on deputy Tejashwi





6. Jul. 27, 2017-Nov. 12, 2020
Alliance with BJP: Finishes term with BJP; a plus was JD(U)'s big win in 2019 LS poll. Deputy Sushil Modi is buffer with BJP bosses

7. Nov. 16, 2020-Aug. 9, 2022
Alliance with BJP: JD(U) seats down to 43 in 2020 polls, CM Nitish blames BJP for backing Chirag Paswan and trying to cut him down

8. Aug. 10, 2022-Jan. 28, 2024
Alliance with RJD-Cong.: Dumps BJP for trying to "do an Eknath Shinde" on his JD(U). Tejashwi is reluctant, but Lalu makes him agree to back Nitish

9. Jan. 28, 2024- **Alliance with BJP:** Disillusioned with I.N.D.I.A., Nitish back in BJP embrace

What also prompted Nitish apparently was feedback from his 16 Lok Sabha MPs that the party's prospects would be better if they fought as NDA candidates. A confidential internal survey report had also indicated that the JD(U) and RJD supporters remained antagonistic to each other at the ground level. The BJP's victories in two of the three assembly byelections held in 2022 after Nitish bolted from the NDA had already indicated that the alliance wasn't working out on the ground, say JD(U) leaders. Indeed, if they are to be believed, even his 'Luv-Kush' (Kurmi-Kushwaha) voters and sympathisers among the EBCs (Extremely Backward Classes) and Mahadalits are apparently more comfortable in the company of the BJP's Brahmin-Rajput-Bhumihar voters than the M-Y cohorts of the RJD.

Nitish also seems to have noted that his momentous 'caste count' in Bihar and expansion of the reservation pie has failed to fire up the social imagination. The Bihar CM has switched alliances foregoing the sizeable proportion of the M-Y (Muslim-Yadav) votes of the RJD. The recent caste count had put Yadavs as the single largest caste group in Bihar, making up over 14 per cent of the population while the Muslims make up 17.7 per cent. But it seems the deal with the BJP looked sweeter as it may strengthen his support base among the 26 per cent Hindu EBCs and their leaders—Muslim EBCs are another 10 per cent.

That said, life will not be easy after the general election and the BJP's choice of abrasive deputy CMs highlights this. A JD(U) source says Nitish is aware of this, which is why expanding the JD(U)'s social base is a top priority. "Our party got about 33 per cent votes in the seats we contested in the 2020 assembly poll when we put up our worst performance. So, it's not like our core voters have deserted us," says the source. The general election will be an experiment in this too—whether, with the BJP by its side, the JD(U) can attract the dominant castes that have so far remained aloof aloof from it.

The plan sounds good on paper, but the voter is an unknown quantity here and the diminishing returns at the hustings in the past couple of elections should worry Nitish. But then, perhaps that is the biggest reason for this switcheroo—the belief that the BJP may have enough wind in its sails to improve their ally's position too in the coming general election. ■